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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The **1906 San Francisco Earthquake** was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history, striking the city of San Francisco on April 18, 1906.

What happened

- A massive earthquake—estimated around magnitude 7.8—ruptured along the San Andreas Fault, which runs through much of coastal California.
- The shaking lasted less than a minute but caused widespread structural collapse.
- Even more destructive were the fires that broke out afterward and burned for several days, destroying large parts of the city.

Immediate impact

- Around 3,000 people died, and over 200,000 were left homeless (more than half the city's population at the time).
- About 80% of San Francisco was destroyed.
- Water mains broke during the quake, making it nearly impossible to fight the fires.

Factors that shaped today's landscape

1. Urban redesign and rebuilding

- The disaster forced a complete rebuilding of San Francisco.
- Streets were widened in some areas, and new building materials (like steel and reinforced concrete) became more common.
- Although ambitious redesign plans (like those by Daniel Burnham) weren't fully implemented, the rebuilding still modernized the city.

2. Stronger building codes

- The earthquake led to major advances in earthquake engineering.
- Modern building codes in California—especially in San Francisco—are among the strictest in the world, designed to withstand seismic activity.

3. Scientific breakthroughs

- The event helped scientists better understand earthquakes and plate tectonics.
- Studies of the quake contributed to the development of the **elastic rebound theory**, explaining how stress builds and releases along faults.

4. Neighborhood patterns

- Entire neighborhoods were rebuilt or reshaped.
- Some areas (like the Marina District, later developed on landfill) remain more vulnerable to shaking and liquefaction today.

5. Infrastructure changes

- The failure of water systems led to improved emergency planning and redundant utilities.
- Firefighting systems, reservoirs, and pipelines were redesigned with disasters in mind.

6. Population and economic shifts

- Many residents temporarily relocated to nearby areas like Oakland and across the Bay, accelerating regional growth.
- San Francisco rebuilt quickly and remained a major economic hub, but the Bay Area became more interconnected.

Big picture

The 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy San Francisco—it reshaped how cities prepare for

disasters. Today's skyline, infrastructure, and strict seismic safety standards are direct results of lessons learned from that catastrophe.

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